LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

✅ Fill your basket

Produce items with the lowest evidence of pesticide risk in the Australian context. Conventional versions are generally a reasonable choice - saving your organic budget for the Dirty Dozen.

✅ **More fresh produce is always better than less!** These carry lower residues than most, so fill your basket, and spend your organic dollars where they count most.

1 

Asparagus

Cleanest

Consistently on the EWG Clean Fifteen — fewer than 11% of samples globally show any detectable residues. Short growing season limits spray applications, and thick stalks offer natural protection. Buy AU-grown in season (Sept–Feb) where available.

2 

Avocados

Cleanest

Thick inedible skin. Less than 2% of samples globally show any residues. Consistently the cleanest item on any produce list.

3 

Bananas

Peeled before eating — flesh well protected. 2026 EWG Clean Fifteen. Note: conventional banana skins carry post-harvest fungicide residues — avoid feeding peels to wildlife.

4 

Beetroot

Underground crop, thick skin almost always peeled. Low pest pressure. Low residues internationally.

5 

Cabbage

Outer leaves discarded. Produces glucosinolates that naturally deter insects, reducing how much spraying is needed.

6 

Carrots

Underground crop, skin discarded. On 2026 EWG Clean Fifteen. Low residue data in AU and globally.

7 

Cauliflower

Dense tightly packed head, outer leaves discarded. Low residues in all available data. Predominantly AU-grown.

8 

Eggplant

Thick skin, lower pest pressure than thin-skinned crops. Low detection rates. Predominantly AU-grown.

9 

Frozen garden peas (shelled)

Protective pod discarded before freezing. Very low residues. Distinct from snow peas — the whole pod is not eaten.

10 

Kiwifruit

Skin not consumed. 82% of samples globally had zero detectable residues in the flesh.

11 

Leeks

Allium family — outer layers discarded. Low pest pressure. Predominantly AU-grown. Consistent with onion and shallot residue profile.

12 

Mangoes

Thick inedible skin, low residues. Buy local QLD/NT where possible — interstate transit treatment applies to some mangoes.

13 

Mushrooms

Grown in controlled indoor environments in AU. Low pesticide use. Generally low residues in available data.

14 

Onions

Papery outer skin. Low pest pressure. Very low residues in AU data. Allium family consistently clean.

15 

Papaya / Pawpaw

Thick skin, flesh well-protected. Low detection rates. Both AU-grown and imported perform well globally.

16 

Pineapples

Very thick inedible skin — near-zero residue detections globally. Mainly imported but flesh is well protected.

17 

Pumpkin

Thick inedible skin. Low pest pressure. Flesh consistently clean globally. Predominantly AU-grown.

18 

Shallots & spring onions

Allium family — papery layers, low pest pressure. Short-cycle crop, predominantly AU-grown. Low residues.

19 

Sweet corn

Husk protection. Very low residues. AU sweet corn is non-GMO unlike many US equivalents.

20 

Sweet potato

Underground crop, skin usually peeled. Low residue rates. A common AU kitchen staple with a reassuring profile.

21 

Watermelon

Very thick rind. Flesh well insulated from chemicals. Low residues across all global studies consistently.

✅ **GENERAL PRACTICES**

- → Check country of origin - AU-grown Dirty Dozen items are preferable to imported equivalents
- → Soak in baking soda solution (1 tsp per 2 cups water, 15 minutes) then rinse - reduces surface residues more effectively than water alone
- → Farmers markets - ask about spray practices; many small AU farms use organic methods without formal certification
- → Grow your own - focus effort on Dirty Dozen crops: strawberries, leafy greens, kale, and berries

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth AU (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →

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